days will leave Europe on 10 February and reach Bombay before the end of the month.' VOC added, 'Considering it advisable not to disclose the names of the steamers and steam launches that would ply between Tuticorin and Colombo, we had thus far desisted from it. However, we shall be publishing all these details in *Swadesamitran* in a few days.'[48] The cloak-and-dagger language in which this missive was couched indicates the not unreasonable fears that he entertained of possible sabotage of the deal not only by the company's rivals, viz. BI but by insiders as well.

From this we can gather that by January 1907 two steamers had been purchased—or at least an agreement for the purchase had been made. Evidently, earnest money had been paid and an understanding reached about payment in instalments. As we shall see, the full settlement took an inordinately long time, bleeding the company and bringing it to the brink of collapse. SSNCo later rued this decision:

> The original promoters … purchased steamers without capital on hand for paying the purchase money … They were allured by the modern facility of making purchases by prepayment of a fractional share of the purchase money. The flow of capital subsequently, though not very bad in the aggregate, was never in time to enable punctual payments of the subsequent instalments. Loans had to be contracted in the interim, from time to time, to make the payments of the instalments, with the general result that the financial position of the company was throughout one of unpreparedness.[49]

This was being wise after the incident. If the business was started only after the capital had been collected it would never have happened. In any case, who would invest in a shipping company which had no ships? But we are getting ahead of the story.

Who was handling the purchase in Europe if VOC was stationed in Bombay? Let us recall VOC's sworn statement that he had effected the purchase through 'a European friend'. The friend remains unidentified. But who was the company's man on the spot? An early report in *Bande Mataram* mentioned some agents of SSNCo.[50] A week or so later *Bande Mataram* mentions S. Vedamurthi Mudaliar as the person who actually inspected the ships at Marseilles.[51] Who was this man entrusted with this crucial task?